# POETICS




# The Gift

## CLASSIC FOR A REASON, 25 CENTURIES OF LITERATURE FROM EVERY PART OF THE GLOBE ARE WAITING FOR YOU

# A Gift Across Time & Space

Public school ruined literature for me. I'm sure some smart people in a committee determined that a given set of assigned readings would open the eyes of America's youth to the joy of reading, but after trickling down through the layers of unenthusiastic bureaucracy and underpaid teachers, these texts arrived on my desk as not a joy but a task to be addressed. Cram it, pass it. I'm clearly not alone, an entire industry was spawned to turn uninspired readings into test results making "CliffNotes" into a house-hold name.

Today we have a wealth of opportunities to open the world of classic literature and appreciate it anew. New and improved translations remove the "thee" and "thou" of ancient texts to make them feel as contemporary as the day they were written. Audiobooks suit the minds of some better than the page, and wonderful low cost paperbacks appeal to the whims of others, while eBooks offer accessibility for a wide range of readers with special needs. No matter who you are or what your circumstance the last 25 centuries are full of gems from across the globe to entertain, enliven and enrich our lives.

The incomparable Alan Rickman playing The Metatron in Kevin Smith's *Dogma* rightly said, "Tell a person you're the Metatron and they stare at you blankly; mention something out of a Charlton Heston movie and they're suddenly theology scholars." Just so, we owe a great debt to Christopher Nolan for building on the Emily Wilson translation of *The Odyssey* to bring Homer's great sequel of an epic to the hearts and minds of modern audiences in a fresh and compellingly contemporary way. I can only hope that some percentage of persons realize that Virgil of Rome wrote a third part, The Aeneid, which explains that the fallen Trojans launched a party to find a new home that would ultimately become the Roman Empire.

In this issue we hope to open your eyes to titles which you may or may not be familiar with that are wonderful. That will bring to your life joy, wisdom, and connect you to stories across time and space that bring each of us closer to our fellow humans to reflect as did King Solomon 2,960 years ago, "There is nothing new under the sun."

Ben & Tamarah

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# AMERICAN MASTERPIECES

## *Moby Dick* by Herman Melville

Forget about the whale already! Surprisingly little of book is actually about the infamous obsession of Captain Ahab and his death feud with the eponymous whale. This is an "encyclopedic novel", interspersed throughout the narrative story it contains chapters on every aspect of whale one could imagine. How to cook whale. Whales in art. Whales in history. The economy around whales. You will learn so much about whales that you'll rush to tell your friends at dinner parties all the incredible facts that astounded you. Never dull and always enriching this book is an gem oft taken for granted.

## *Gone with the Wind* by Margaret Mitchell

Quite likely the greatest American novel ever produced, our *Anna Karenina*, it has fallen out of favor, party because it deals with a disturbing time in American history and partly because the film became a popular romance that appealed more to a female than male audience. Even so, this novel is epic in scope and written masterfully. The story is compelling and the details are, at time, shocking and revealing. To understand what we are we must be honest about who we were and this novel is uniquely American to its core. If you love banned books you'll eat this one up.

## *Slaughterhouse-Five* by Kurt Vonnegut

Frequently misunderstood and perhaps the worst movie adaptation in the history of film, if you read this in school and didn't enjoy or get it, you should come back on your own terms. A fun, insightful, and at times hilarious book centered around a single question: How do you tell a war story that doesn't glorify war? To this end, whenever something terrible happens we hear the refrain, "So it goes."

## *Catch-22* by Joseph Heller

A book so outrageous it has to be American. Funny and ridiculous it is several times over laugh-out-loud hilarious. Featuring all the insanity of the bureaucracy surrounding WW-II bomber missions and all the myriad ways our actions become increasingly outrageous in the face of outrageous circumstances. Forever it etched the term Catch-22 in our vernacular and is a shining American take on the Kafkaesque mind-wrenching paradoxes of modern bureaucracy.

# FORGOTTEN GEMS

## *Lost in the Funhouse* by John Barth

Short stories rarely get the respect they deserve. This gem was part of the foundation of what would become known as American Post-Modern Literature. Aware of itself as a story, the author argues and criticizes the story as he's writing it, seemingly unable to control his own creation, frequently breaking the literary fourth-wall in a precursor to the kind of irreverence we've come to know from Ryan Renyolds's portrayal as Deadpool.

## *Tevye The Dairyman* by Sholem Aleichem

A series of Yiddish short stories written between 1894 and 1914 to bring hope, levity, and comfort to Eastern European Jews in hard times, the hero Tevye and his wife Golde deal with a wide range of situations and hardships surrounding their family of seven daughters. Bits of pieces of these stories, along with the characters themselves, became the basis for the wildly popular *Fiddler on the Roof*. These stories have a timeless quality that any parent can relate to.

## *Notes from the Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky

A tonic for anyone depressed, this novella features the diary of a miserable and complicated man who is at war with himself and the world. "I am a sick man.... I am a spiteful man. I am an unattractive man. I believe my liver is diseased." In a world he can never be comfortable in he tries this and that, generally making things only worse. In your most depressed moments it is oddly comforting to be in the presence of someone even more depressed than yourself and realize you are not alone.

## *Zorba the Greek* by Nikos Kazantzakis

The classic story of a bookish sheltered nerd meeting a larger-than-life live-for-the-moment man and realizing that life is for the living. Variations of this story have been with us as long as stories have, but this telling is perhaps the most compelling. Zorba is a character so full of life he's one you'll carry with you always and remind you that life and the depths of emotion are a well so deep that only dance can truly express them.

## *Orlando* by Virginia Woolf

A man turns into a woman over a 350 year lifespan in this incredible modernist masterpiece that is often overlooked. Particularly in this era of gender debate, this classic ought to have more fanfare. Woolf's stream of consciousness style is on full display, perhaps more acutely than the more famous *Mrs. Dalloway*. A fascinating and thought-provoking read and classic of the magical-realism tradition.

# CLASSIC VERSE

## *Metamorphoses* by Ovid

Did *The Odyssey* whet your appetite for epic poetry? Ovid's masterpiece starts with the creation of the world and works forward in a long but fascinating retelling of the many tales of the ancient world. Best enjoyed in small doses, this epic has it all, literally, and is sure to delight and educate you on oh so many stories you'd only heard summarized elsewhere.

## *The Tempest* by Shakespeare

The final poem of the bard, often overlooked and under-appreciated, this play written in unrhymed iambic pentameter has a beautiful sing-song swagger that delights the mind. As Shakespeare's grand finale it has everything, romance, magic, fantasy, comedy, and wisdom. Whats more, it is unspoiled by a popular movie rendition, so sit back and enjoy the master at his finest.

## *Howl and Other Poems* by Allen Ginsberg

Every generation has its own counter-culture movement. Many modern groups find their grounding in music (hippies, punks, goths, emo, ravers, etc.) but The Beats, later dubbed beatniks, stand out for having built their foundations upon a literary movement codified by Kerouac, Ginsberg, and Burroughs. A tremendous amount of bad poetry was subsequently produced but it was grounded in the truth of one's experience that "Howl" demonstrated so well.

## *The Dolphin* by Robert Lowell

"my eyes have seen what my hand did.", a haunting and powerful collection of Lowell's unrhymed sonnets published in 1973 that chronicles the collapse of his 21-year marriage to writer Elizabeth Hardwick and his move to England with Lady Caroline Blackwood. Anyone in a hard time of life and look to Lowell for the words to describe that which is indescribable.

## *Death of a Naturalist* by Seamus Heaney

Pay special attention to its star poem, "Mid Term Break." The Irish have a special magical powers with verse and here Seamus is at his best right out of the gate in his debut collection. This book strikes a chord because it is about growing up and losing innocence. It captures that exact moment when childhood wonder turns into adult reality, like realizing nature can be gross or dangerous. An oft overlooked gem that is wise and accessible.

## *Ecclesiastes* by King Solomon

"To every thing there is a season, and a time to every purpose under the heaven: A time to be born, and a time to die; a time to plant, and a time to pluck [...]." Purportedly dating to 935 BC, this is a powerful work of poetry that retains its vitality after almost 3,000 is still relevant and a balm to any person who says to themselves "What is the point?" Often overlooked and under appreciated this gem is hiding in your nearest Bible ready to soothe your existential crisis.

# SONNET 18

*by William Shakespeare*

Shall I compare thee to a summer's day?
Thou art more lovely and more temperate:
Rough winds do shake the darling buds of May,
And summer's lease hath all too short a date;
Sometime too hot the eye of heaven shines,
And often is his gold complexion dimm'd;
And every fair from fair sometime declines,
By chance or nature's changing course untrimm'd;
But thy eternal summer shall not fade,
Nor lose possession of that fair thou ow'st;
Nor shall death brag thou wander'st in his shade,
When in eternal lines to time thou grow'st:
  So long as men can breathe or eyes can see,
  So long lives this, and this gives life to thee.

# ODE ON A GRECIAN URN

*by John Keats*

Thou still unravish'd bride of quietness,
    Thou foster-child of silence and slow time,
Sylvan historian, who canst thus express
    A flowery tale more sweetly than our rhyme:
What leaf-fring'd legend haunts about thy shape
    Of deities or mortals, or of both,
        In Tempe or the dales of Arcady?
    What men or gods are these? What maidens loth?
What mad pursuit? What struggle to escape?
        What pipes and timbrels? What wild ecstasy?

Heard melodies are sweet, but those unheard
    Are sweeter; therefore, ye soft pipes, play on;
Not to the sensual ear, but, more endear'd,
    Pipe to the spirit ditties of no tone:
Fair youth, beneath the trees, thou canst not leave
    Thy song, nor ever can those trees be bare;
        Bold Lover, never, never canst thou kiss,
Though winning near the goal yet, do not grieve;
    She cannot fade, though thou hast not thy bliss,
        For ever wilt thou love, and she be fair!

Ah, happy, happy boughs! that cannot shed
     Your leaves, nor ever bid the Spring adieu;
And, happy melodist, unwearied,
     For ever piping songs for ever new;
More happy love! more happy, happy love!
     For ever warm and still to be enjoy'd,
         For ever panting, and for ever young;
All breathing human passion far above,
     That leaves a heart high-sorrowful and cloy'd,
         A burning forehead, and a parching tongue.

Who are these coming to the sacrifice?
     To what green altar, O mysterious priest,
Lead'st thou that heifer lowing at the skies,
     And all her silken flanks with garlands drest?
What little town by river or sea shore,
     Or mountain-built with peaceful citadel,
         Is emptied of this folk, this pious morn?
And, little town, thy streets for evermore
     Will silent be; and not a soul to tell
         Why thou art desolate, can e'er return.

O Attic shape! Fair attitude! with brede
     Of marble men and maidens overwrought,
With forest branches and the trodden weed;
     Thou, silent form, dost tease us out of thought
As doth eternity: Cold Pastoral!
     When old age shall this generation waste,
         Thou shalt remain, in midst of other woe
Than ours, a friend to man, to whom thou say'st,
     "Beauty is truth, truth beauty,—that is all
         Ye know on earth, and all ye need to know."

# THE SENSE OF MOVEMENT

*by Tamarah Rockwood*

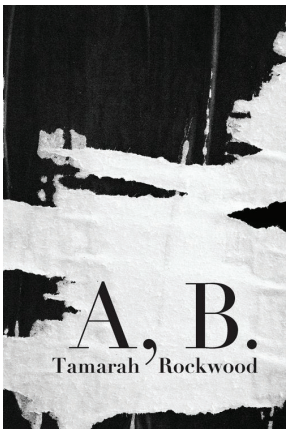
On Sunday, I finally decided
To try oat milk in my coffee,
After years of listening to advertisements,
Friends, and siblings declare allegiance.

I have never had an issue with cow's milk,
Nor have I had the habit of adding milk
To my coffee, nor do I eat cereal, nor
Have I thought too long about my own milk-fidelity.

Nevertheless, it feels like times are moving.
In the store, I notice more alternatives
Drawing people away from what we grew up with,
What we expect to be the accepted.

Maybe the cows might need a breather;
Maybe the orchards are eager to lean in;

Or perhaps it is we who are eager to see a change
Of color across the aisles,
As we are eager to see blossoms on the trees
Bursting in prom-pink at the cusp of spring.




From Tamarah's 2023 collection "A, B."
Included here for a little last page fun.

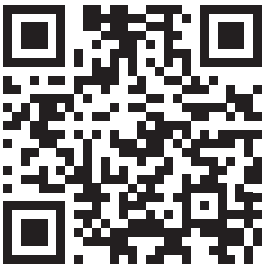
“IF YOU ONLY READ THE BOOKS THAT EVERYONE ELSE IS READING, **YOU CAN ONLY THINK WHAT EVERYONE ELSE IS THINKING.**”

**– HARUKI MURAKAMI , NORWEGIAN WOOD.**

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# POETRY LIVES HERE

## Bainbridge Island Press

*Bainbridge Island, WA*